inherent nature (***svabhava***). He says that entities with essential natures would have to be uncaused or self-created, which is impossible. There cannot be any ***dharmas*** with essences or immutable natures. If reality basically consisted of ***dharmas*** possessing essence, the universe would be static and there would be no changes. If the unsatisfactory round of existences (***samsara***) had essence, there would be no possibility of ***nirvana*** and if ***nirvana*** had essence, there would be no ***samsara***. Buddhists believe that everything in the world arises in dependence upon causes (***hetu***) and conditioning factors (***pratyaya***). All Buddhists accept that conditioned entities lack essence. *Nagarjuna* insists that whatever is interdependently originated (***pratitya-samutpada***) is also devoid of essential nature. Lack of essence does not follow simply from the fact of being interdependently originated. There cannot be any essences.

If there are no essences, there are no stable entities with clearly demarcated boundaries or identities. But *Nagarjuna* is not a nihilist. The absence of essences does not mean that we do not inhabit a world of changing realities.

He denies that causation is a real relation. Events happen in succession and our minds impose associations that we treat as causal realities. But we do not see causal forces. Moreover, there are no types, kinds or classes of entities with intrinsic causal powers.

If there are no essences, the ***Abhidharma*** distinction between conventional reality and ultimate reality (***dharmas*** with essential natures) collapses. There is no difference between ***samsara*** and ***nirvana***. We cannot produce a complete and correct description of reality that is independent of any particular perspective. It is pointless to entertain the possibility that there is an ultimate truth accessible to the finite conceptual capacities and schemes,